

FAKE WIVES FOR SALE

Given the skewed sex ratio in Haryana, desperate bachelors become easy victims of organised gangs



Photographs by SIPRA DAS

■ By Mihir Srivastava

Sukhdev Singh, 30, a contract labourer from village Kharakha in Sikar district in rural Haryana was desperate to get married. His parents, Hasan Ram and Ranu Bai, had tried to find a match for him but after seven fruitless years they finally gave up. The reason for the shortage of brides lies in Haryana's sex ratio which is acutely skewed with 861 females for every thousand males. In other words, out of every hundred males, 14 would be unable to find a bride. The brunt of this problem is felt the most by poor, rural males. "If you are poor, without job and have small land holding then you get no girls to marry," says Ranu Bai. Like other areas where demand outstrips supply,

illegal rackets start flourishing, with devastating consequences, as was the case with Sukhdev. In May, his uncle Jeet Singh arranged a meeting with two women, Kartaro (from Rajasthan) and Charno (from Punjab), at Dabwali, a nearby town. They promised to fulfill Sukhdev's long-pending desire to get married. They showed Gurcharan Singh, Sukhdev's brother-in-law who had come to finalise the marriage on his behalf, the prospective bride, Guddi. She looked too good to be true. Gurcharan immediately agreed to the marriage proposal and paid some token money.

That's when the racket unveiled itself. Kartaro and Charno demanded Rs 35,000. "They said the girl's family was very poor and needed monetary help to perform the marriage

THE DUPED: Sukhdev with his family and neighbours

rites," says Ranu Bai. Sukhdev's family, who earn barely Rs 5,000 a month, could not meet the demand but relatives and other villagers pitched in. "We all gave whatever we could, after all it was the question of Sukhdev's life," says his neighbour Mukhiyaro. Kartaro and Charno were paid in two installments. The marriage was fixed for May 28 at Dabwali. When the *baraat* reached the venue, it wore a deserted look. On being confronted, Kartaro and Charno produced Rani, a middle-aged widow with two grown up children. She was not the girl Gurcharan had seen. "They cheated us. Obviously, I refused to marry Rani," says Sukhdev. Kartaro and